Holy Saturday and Long Term Memory

By James Tate

INTRODUCTION

There is a philosophy of interconnectedness . . . Everyone you meet in your life — even total strangers — is already intimately connected to you. The idea that we are all separate and distinct beings is nothing but an illusion. We are all parts of a larger whole, like individual cells in a body.

You don't have to "build" relationships with others because you're already connected. You need only tune into the pre-existing connection that's already there. All relationships are significant; none are irrelevant. Even the strangers you pass on the street are important parts of you.

No one makes this point more eloquently than James Tate in his narrative poem, Holy Saturday.

Holy Saturday

I came out of the store, and the first thing I saw was a man in a bunny suit dancing down the sidewalk, handing out chocolate eggs to everyone. Never take candy from strangers was the first thing that leapt to mind. I

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wanted to reach the car before he caught up with me. He saw this, and took a giant hop in my direction. "Here, this is for you, Mr. Get-away-as-fast-as-you-can," he said.

"I don't want it," I said. "I'm allergic to chocolate."

He made a fist with his paw and threatened my nose. "Take it, " he said, "you can give it to a child, and they will thank you."

"I don't know any children, and besides, how do I know there isn't arsenic in there. I don't know you. You're a complete stranger to me. You might be an escaped convict, a child molester, or a murderer."

"I'm the Easter bunny, you asshole. If you can't trust the Easter bunny, you're in pretty bad shape. Take the egg before I shove it down your throat," he said.

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I grabbed him by the shoulders and threw him up against my car. The whiskers on his nose were twitching. His long, floppy ears looked pathetic. "You are about to become a very wounded bunny," I said.

"Maybe we could talk this over, over a beer or something. What do you say?" the bunny said.

A couple of teenagers had gathered to see what I might do next. They were excited. I, who've never been in a fight, really wanted to punch the bunny. But, instead, I dragged him off the car. I took his basket out of his paw and threw it in the trash can. "Now go home and get out of that suit. There's enough crime in this town without you impersonating the Easter bunny and handing out suspicious substances to little children," I said.

"I was trying to do a good thing," he said. "I was trying to bring a little cheer and good will, that's all."

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"But you've got a bunny suit on, for God's sake. And you were dancing on the sidewalk like an idiot. Why should anyone trust you?" I said.

"Let's rip that suit off of him and see who he really is," one of the teenagers said. The bunny looked really frightened. He was half bent over, as if about to hop.

"No," I said, "I think he's learned his lesson" The boys seemed disappointed, and I was starting to worry about the safety of the bunny. "Get in the car," I said to him.

"What?" he said. "I said, get in the car. I'll drive you home." I unlocked the car and got into the driver's seat. The bunny seemed confused, but did as I had said. He told me where he lived, and we drove there in silence. He lived in a run-down apartment complex. Half the domestic crime in town took place right there. When I stopped he started to open the door. He looked so defeated.

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"What do you do, I mean, in real life?" I said.

"I'm unemployed right now," he said. "Every time I get a job the place closes down. It's like I'm the kiss of death." Hearing this from a raggedy-assed Easter bunny should have been funny, but it wasn't. It nearly broke my heart.

"I'm sorry I ruined your day. Honestly, I don't know what came over me. Maybe I was envious of your happiness," I said.

"That's what's great about the bunny suit," he said, "no one can see your tears. Thanks for the ride. After nearly killing me, you saved my life. Makes a perfect story. Unfortunately, I've got no one to tell it to." He got out of the car and started hopping across the little, gravelly yard. I never even saw his face or got his name.

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TRANSITION

And another memory is stored . . . . Elizabeth Loftus once said, "We fill in gaps in our memory using chains of events that are logically acceptable. Our biases, expectations, and past knowledge are all used in the filling-in process, leading to distortions in what we remember." And when other s encourage these possible memories, the leap to remembered greatness can sometimes be quite, quite small. Long-Term Memory by James Tate.

Long-Term Memory

I was sitting in the park feeding pigeons when a man came over to me and scrutinized my face right up close. "There's a statue of you over there," he said. "You should be dead. What did you do to deserve a statue?" "I've never seen a statue of me," I said. "There can't be a statue of me. I've never done anything to deserve a statue. And I'm definitely not dead." "Well, go look for yourself. It's you alright, there's no mistaking that," he said. I got up and walked over where it was. It was me alright. I looked like I was gazing off into the distance, or the

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future, like those statues of pioneers. It didn't have my name on it or anything, but it was me.

A lady came up to me and said, "You're looking at your own statue. Isn't that against the law, or something?" "It should be," I said, "but this is my first offense. Maybe they'll let me off light."

"It's against nature, too," she said, "and bad manners, I think." "I couldn't agree with you more," I said. "I'm walking away right now, sorry."

I went back to my bench. The man was sitting there. "Maybe you're a war hero. Maybe you died in the war," he said. "Never been a soldier," I said.

"Maybe you founded this town three hundred years ago," he said. "Well, if I did, I don't remember it now," I said. "That's a long time ago," he said, "you coulda forgot." I went back to feeding the pigeons. Oh, yes, founding the town. It was coming back to me now. It was on a Wednesday.

A light rain, my horse slowed . . .

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